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Psychology of International Relations

Fall 2026, v0.2

Course Number: ISDI7615IA

Semester and Year: Fall 2026

Credits: 3 credits; 13 weeks; one 1-hour-50-minute session per week

Meeting Time and Location: Thursday 1:10 pm – 3:00 pm

Course Description

If international politics is governed by states as rational as our traditional theories assume, why does it appear so unpredictable in practice? Does this instability reflect the irrationality of decision-makers, or does it suggest that conventional theories have misunderstood the nature of rationality itself? This course begins from a simple but consequential premise: like all forms of politics, international politics is ultimately shaped by human beings. Although this observation may seem self-evident, its implications have often been overlooked because the state, rather than the individual, has traditionally served as the primary unit of analysis in international relations. The course therefore asks how understanding the workings of the human mind can deepen our explanations of international conflict, cooperation, war, and peace.

This course explores the growing field of psychological approaches to international relations, examining how insights from psychology can refine existing theories and generate new explanations of international politics. Rather than surveying the field as a series of discrete topics, the course is organized around a sequence of interconnected questions, with each week building on problems raised in the previous one.

Unit 1 introduces the course's foundational questions: Why is psychology necessary for understanding international politics, and what does a psychological perspective imply for conventional assumptions about rationality? Unit 2 examines how central subjects of psychological inquiry, including cognition, emotion, and decision-making, relate to the core concerns of international relations. Unit 3 addresses the level-of-analysis problem by investigating how individual psychological processes become linked to state behavior and broader political outcomes. The final unit applies these perspectives to prominent questions in world politics, including the influence of leaders' personalities, the psychological foundations of international norms, and the enduring legacies of political violence.

Learning Objectives

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

- Diagnose when rational-actor assumptions are adequate for a policy problem and when psychological models make systematically better predictions.
- Apply core concepts from political psychology (prospect theory, misperception, emotion, operational codes, social identity, status) to analyze specific foreign policy decisions and crises.
- Evaluate leaders and decision-making bodies "at a distance" using established profiling and content-analysis approaches employed by governments and researchers.
- Anticipate how mass publics will respond to foreign policy events, and assess how public opinion constrains or enables policy choices.
- Produce professional policy analysis as a team, a decision memo and a briefing to the class, that translates psychological research into actionable guidance and holds up under questioning.

Workload and Final Deliverables

Weekly preparation

This course combines lecture and seminar-style discussion. This course is reading intensive, and you should be prepared to read approximately 100–150 pages for each class meeting. Students are expected to **complete the assigned readings before each class and arrive prepared to discuss them**. There are no required textbooks for this course. All readings will be posted on the course CourseWorks site. Readings should be completed in preparation for the day of class on which they are assigned.

Final deliverable

The course is organized around a **semester-long policy memo project**. Working in teams of four or five, students will select a contemporary or historical problem or crisis in international relations in which psychological dynamics play a consequential role. Each group will assume the role of an advisory team to a government official or international organization. Drawing on theories and concepts from political psychology, groups will analyze how psychological processes shape the problem and recommend a concrete, feasible, and evidence-based course of action.

A policy memo is a concise, evidence-based document written for a specific decision-maker confronting a real or realistically constructed foreign policy problem. A strong policy memo should:

- Clearly define the policy problem, decision context, intended audience, and decision to be made.

- Provide a concise executive summary that enables an informed, non-specialist policymaker to understand the problem, analysis, and recommendation. Avoid unnecessary jargon, define essential concepts, and prioritize analytical clarity over comprehensiveness.
- Develop an analytically grounded diagnosis of why the problem has emerged or persisted, applying relevant course concepts such as cognitive biases, emotional appraisals, identity processes, or belief-system dynamics. Rather than merely summarizing the academic literature, the memo should use these concepts to diagnose the problem and identify possible solutions.
- Evaluate specific and feasible policy options, including their likely political, psychological, and strategic consequences.
- Present a clear policy recommendation supported by credible evidence and explicit reasoning.
- Anticipate implementation challenges, unintended consequences, and likely responses from relevant actors.

To avoid concentrating the project's assessment in a single high-stakes submission, groups will complete two short check-in assignments during the semester, each designed to move the analysis forward while there is still time to change course. The final policy memo is due on Friday, November 20, and each group will deliver its policy briefing to the class on December 10.

Assignments and Grading

Grading Breakdown (total = 100%)

Component	Weight
Class participation	20%
Discussion leading	20%
Response posts	10%
Policy memo	30%
Final briefing	20%
Total:	100%

Final grades are calibrated to SIPA's expectation of a roughly B+ (3.33) class average. This reflects overall academic judgment rather than a fixed curve or a percentage-to-letter conversion.

1) Class participation (20%)

This course is designed around expectations of active and sustained engagement with the readings, lectures, and class discussions. Please allow your peers to extract a benefit from your

study and insight. Participation will be assessed primarily on evidence that students have completed the assigned readings and are engaging substantively with the course material. Meaningful participation may take several forms, including asking thoughtful questions, offering comments grounded in the readings or lectures, reconstructing or critiquing arguments, introducing relevant examples, and connecting course concepts to current events. The quality, relevance, and consistency of contributions will matter more than the frequency with which a student speaks. Regular attendance is expected and work completed during class cannot be made up following an unexcused absence.

In addition to this principle, participation will also incorporate the following components:

1. Completion of the preliminary online survey by September 14.
2. Periodic participation check-ins and self-assessments.
3. Occasional in-class writing exercises.

Students who are less comfortable speaking in class may, with the instructor's approval, fulfill part of the participation requirement through designated asynchronous activities. Students seeking this accommodation must consult the instructor and receive approval by the end of Week 3.

2) Discussion leading (20%)

Each student will serve as a discussion leader once during the semester. Two to three students will lead in any given week. Leading is not a book report: everyone in the room has done the same reading, so your job is to bring something to it that the rest of us would not have arrived at on our own.

As a discussion leader you will:

- **Analyze the readings of the week comprehensively, with one reading of choice as your anchor reading.** You will foreground that reading in your memo and your presentation, while still engaging the week's other readings. Co-leaders in the same week must choose different anchors; anchors are claimed on the sign-up sheet, first come, first served.
- **Post a two-page reflection memo to CourseWorks by Monday at 9:00 p.m.** The memo should include a brief reconstruction of what the week's readings argue and where they disagree; followed with your own comparative analysis, implications, or objections, led by your anchor reading; and at least two discussion questions for the seminar. Double-spaced.
- **Present for five to ten minutes in class**, ten minutes being a hard maximum. Slides are not required and are usually not worth the trouble at this length.
- **Read the response posts to your memo before class.** They are due Wednesday at noon, and part of your job in the room is to take up what your classmates raised.

Sign-up opens on CourseWorks in Week 1 and remains open through Week 2, so that students who join during the add/drop period can still choose. Slots run from Week 2 through Week 12 and are first come, first served.

The memo is assessed on the quality of the analysis rather than the coverage: an accurate account of the readings is the floor, not the achievement. The presentation is assessed on the extent to which it contributes meaningful perspectives that enrich the classroom discussion.

3) Response posts (10%)

Four times during the semester you will respond to the memos from discussion leaders. Your assigned weeks will be randomly decided and published on CourseWorks in Week 2, so you can plan around them.

Posts are due Wednesday at noon, which gives the leaders time to read them before class. Aim for 150 to 250 words. A response should engage a claim, either the leader's or one made in the readings themselves, rather than summarize or endorse. Extending an argument, supplying a case that strains it, or naming the assumption the leader passed over are all good moves. "I agree, this was interesting" is not.

Posts are graded on a three-point check scale: ✓+ for a response that gives the leader something to work with, ✓ for a competent engagement with the material, ✓- for a post that is late, thin, or could have been written without doing the reading. A missed post receives no credit.

4) Policy memo (30%)

The policy memo is a group project, and a common grade will be assigned to all members of the group. Exceptions are limited participation is evident in assignment components that require individual contribution. The project is collaborative by design: policy analysis is typically conducted by teams whose members must evaluate competing perspectives and deliberate toward a shared recommendation. The psychological dynamics of that deliberation are themselves an important part of the course. Groups experiencing a serious imbalance in workload should consult the instructor as early as possible, while there is still time to address the problem.

Groups are formed in Week 3, once the roster has settled after the add/drop period. The full project prompt is posted in Week 1. Detailed instructions and the grading rubric for each check-in and for the final memo will be posted on CourseWorks at least one month before the relevant due date. Nothing will be assessed against criteria you have not seen well in advance.

- A. **Check-in 1: Case, Client, Decision (5 points, due Thursday, October 8).** One page. Name the case, the specific decision-maker or organization you are advising, and the decision actually on that client's desk, including what forces it and when. State the psychological

dynamics you expect to be doing the work, and list the evidence base you will draw on. A vague client or a decision with no deadline is the most common way this project goes wrong, and this check-in exists to catch it early.

- B. **Check-in 2: Analysis and Division of Labor (5 points, due Thursday, October 29).** Two pages. A problem statement, the analytical framework you are drawing from the course, and at least two policy options under serious consideration, with the case for and against each. Append a table showing how the work is divided, and a two-sentence statement from each group member describing what they have contributed so far. Groups experiencing a serious imbalance should come talk to me while there is still time to fix it.
- C. **Final Policy Memo (20 points, due Friday, November 20).** Approximately 2,000 words, addressed to your designated decision-maker or organization. The memo should diagnose the problem, explain the psychological dynamics that produced or sustain it, evaluate the principal options, and recommend a concrete and feasible course of action, including its likely costs and the responses it will provoke. Written feedback will be returned by Tuesday, December 1, in time for you to use it in the briefing.

5) Final briefing (20%)

- A. **On December 10**, each group will deliver a policy briefing to the class: ten minutes, to be followed by questions. Brief the decision-maker your memo addresses, not the seminar, and pitch the analysis to an informed non-specialist. This is not a summary of the memo you already submitted. It is the memo after my feedback, and the briefing is where I look for what you did with it.
- B. The question period is part of the assessment. You should expect to be pressed on the options you set aside, on the evidence behind your diagnosis, and on what happens if your recommendation fails.

Attendance Policy

Attendance is expected at all sessions; the seminar works because people are in the room. That said, life happens: you may miss up to three sessions, no questions asked, for any reason. You do not need to provide documentation or explain the absence. Just let me know in advance when you can, and arrange with a classmate to catch up on what you missed. Work done in class cannot be made up, and missing the week you are signed up to lead discussion is a different matter: contact me as far in advance as you can and we will move your slot.

For absences protected by University policy, including religious observance and disability services accommodations, tell me early in the semester and we will plan another way for you to complete anything you miss. These absences do not count against the three above and require no documentation. If a longer illness or personal situation keeps you away from multiple sessions, come talk to me, or ask your Advising Dean in OSA to reach out; we will work something out.

Weekly Readings and Topics

Required Textbooks: None to purchase. All readings will be posted to CourseWorks.

** This schedule is subject to change. Any changes will be announced on CourseWorks and in class.*

UNIT 1: The Case for Psychology

Why international politics needs psychology at all, what that does to the rationality assumption, and why decision-makers act on perception rather than on reality.

Week 1 (September 10) — Does Psychology Belong in IR?

What does a psychological approach to international relations look like, and what does it claim to explain better?

- Mearsheimer, John J., and Sebastian Rosato. 2023. *How states think: The rationality of foreign policy*. Yale University Press. Chapter 1.
- Yarhi-Milo, Keren. 2023. "Why Smart Leaders Do Stupid Things: Is Foreign Policy Rational?" *Foreign Affairs* 102 (6): 154.
- Kertzer, Joshua D., 2024. "How Political Psychologists Think." *Critical Review*, 36(4), pp.427-464.

Week 2 (September 17) — The Rational Tradition of IR Theory

Is psychology opposed to rationality, or do the two approaches complement each other?

- Hafner-Burton, Emilie M., Stephan Haggard, David A. Lake, and David G. Victor. 2017. "The Behavioral Revolution and the Study of International Relations." *International Organization* 71 (S1): S1–S31.
- Mercer, Jonathan. 2005. "Rationality and Psychology in International Politics." *International Organization* 59 (1): 77–106.
- Crawford, Neta C. 2000. "The Passion of World Politics: Propositions on Emotion and Emotional Relationships." *International Security* 24 (4): 116–156.
- Rathbun, Brian C. 2011. "Before Hegemony: Generalized Trust and the Creation and Design of International Security Organizations." *International Organization* 65 (2): 243–273.

Recommended

- Schelling, Thomas C. 1966. *Arms and Influence*. Yale University Press, ch. 2.
- Sen, Amartya K. 1977. "Rational Fools: A Critique of the Behavioral Foundations of Economic Theory." *Philosophy & Public Affairs* 6 (4): 317–344.
- Fearon, James D. 1995. "Rationalist Explanations for War." *International Organization* 49 (3): 379–414 (esp. 379–390).

- Riker, William H. 1995. "The Political Psychology of Rational Choice Theory." *Political Psychology* 16 (1): 23–44.
- Rathbun, Brian C., Joshua D. Kertzer, and Mark Paradis. 2017. "Homo Diplomaticus: Mixed-Method Evidence of Variation in Strategic Rationality." *International Organization* 71 (S1): S33–S60.

Week 3 (September 24) — Perceptions of Reality

If perception rather than reality drives behavior, what follows when decision-makers get it wrong?

- Jervis, Robert. 1976. "Chapter 1: Perception and the Level of Analysis Problem." In *Perception and Misperception in International Politics*, pp. 13–31.
- Herrmann, Richard K., and Michael P. Fischerkeller. 1995. "Beyond the Enemy Image and Spiral Model: Cognitive–Strategic Research after the Cold War." *International Organization* 49 (3): 415–450.
- Duelfer, Charles A., and Stephen Benedict Dyson. 2011. "Chronic Misperception and International Conflict: The U.S.–Iraq Experience." *International Security* 36 (1): 73–100.
- Tomz, Michael R., and Jessica L. P. Weeks. 2013. "Public Opinion and the Democratic Peace." *American Political Science Review* 107 (4): 849–865.

Recommended

- Schafer, Mark, and Stephen G. Walker. 2006. "Democratic Leaders and the Democratic Peace: The Operational Codes of Tony Blair and Bill Clinton." *International Studies Quarterly* 50 (3): 561–583.
- Hall, Todd, and Keren Yarhi-Milo. 2012. "The Personal Touch: Leaders' Impressions, Costly Signaling, and Assessments of Sincerity in International Affairs." *International Studies Quarterly* 56 (3): 560–573.
- Herrmann, Richard K. 2013. "Perceptions and Image Theory in International Relations." In *Oxford Handbook of Political Psychology*, 2nd ed., ed. Huddy, Sears, and Levy. Oxford University Press.
- Davis, James W., and Rose McDermott. 2021. "The Past, Present, and Future of Behavioral IR." *International Organization* 75 (1): 147–177.
- Kertzer, Joshua D., Ryan Brutger, and Kai Quek. 2024. "Perspective Taking and the Security Dilemma: Cross-National Experimental Evidence from China and the United States." *World Politics* 76 (2): 334–378.

UNIT 2: The Machinery of Judgment

Cognition, risk, and emotion: the three processes the field builds on, and what each explains that the others cannot.

Week 4 (October 1) — Biased, Systematically

Which cognitive biases shape foreign-policy decisions, and are their effects systematic enough to anticipate?

- Yarhi-Milo, Keren. 2014. *Knowing the Adversary: Leaders, Intelligence, and Assessment of Intentions in International Relations*. Princeton University Press, chs. 9–10.
- Schwartz, Joshua A., and Christopher W. Blair. 2020. "Do Women Make More Credible Threats? Gender Stereotypes, Audience Costs, and Crisis Bargaining." *International Organization* 74 (4): 872–895.
- Kertzer, Joshua D., Marcus Holmes, Brad L. LeVeck, and Carly Wayne. 2022. "Hawkish Biases and Group Decision Making." *International Organization* 76 (3): 513–548.
- Rapport, Aaron. 2013. "The Long and Short of It: Cognitive Constraints on Leaders' Assessments of 'Postwar' Iraq." *International Security* 37 (3): 133–171.

Recommended

- Tversky, Amos, and Daniel Kahneman. 1974. "Judgment Under Uncertainty: Heuristics and Biases." *Science* 185: 1124–1131.
- Khong, Yuen Foong. 1992. *Analogies at War: Korea, Munich, Dien Bien Phu and the Vietnam Decision of 1965*. Princeton University Press, pp. 51–52, 97–147.
- Levy, Jack S. 1994. "Learning and Foreign Policy: Sweeping a Conceptual Minefield." *International Organization* 48 (2): 279–312.
- Morrow, James D. 1999. "The Strategic Setting of Choices: Signaling, Commitment, and Negotiation in International Politics." In *Strategic Choice and International Relations*, ed. Lake and Powell. Princeton University Press.
- Mellers, Barbara, et al. 2015. "The Psychology of Intelligence Analysis: Drivers of Prediction Accuracy in World Politics." *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Applied* 21 (1): 1–14.

Week 5 (October 8) — Prospect Theory: War and the Psychology of Risk

How do decision-makers choose under risk and uncertainty?

Check-in 1 (case, client, decision) due Thursday, October 8.

- Levy, Jack S. 1992. "An Introduction to Prospect Theory." *Political Psychology* 13 (2): 171–186.
- McDermott, Rose. 1998. *Risk-Taking in International Politics: Prospect Theory in American Foreign Policy*. University of Michigan Press, pp. 45–75.
- Farnham, Barbara. 1992. "Roosevelt and the Munich Crisis: Insights from Prospect Theory." *Political Psychology* 13 (2): 205–235.
- Hafner-Burton, Emilie M., D. Alex Hughes, and David G. Victor. 2013. "The Cognitive Revolution and the Political Psychology of Elite Decision Making." *Perspectives on Politics* 11 (2): 368–386.

Recommended

- Haas, Mark L. 2001. "Prospect Theory and the Cuban Missile Crisis." *International Studies Quarterly* 45 (2): 241–270.
- McDermott, Rose, and Jacek Kugler. 2001. "Comparing Rational Choice and Prospect Theory Analyses: The US Decision to Launch Operation 'Desert Storm', January 1991." *The Journal of Strategic Studies* 24 (3): 49–85.
- Schaub, Gary, Jr. 2004. "Deterrence, Compellence, and Prospect Theory." *Political Psychology* 25 (3): 389–411.
- Butler, Christopher K. 2007. "Prospect Theory and Coercive Bargaining." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 51 (2): 227–250.
- Linde, Jona, and Barbara Vis. 2017. "Do Politicians Take Risks Like the Rest of Us? An Experimental Test of Prospect Theory Under MPs." *Political Psychology* 38 (1): 101–117.

Week 6 (October 15) — Emotions

Can emotions be theorized, and what is gained when they are?

- Mercer, Jonathan. 2010. "Emotional Beliefs." *International Organization* 64 (1): 1–31.
- Lerner, Jennifer S., and Dacher Keltner. 2001. "Fear, Anger, and Risk." *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 81 (1): 146–159.
- Wayne, Carly N. 2023. "Terrified or Enraged? Emotional Microfoundations of Public Counterterror Attitudes." *International Organization* 77 (4): 824–847.
- Masterson, Michael. 2024. "Catching Fire: How National Humiliation Spreads Hostile Foreign Policy Preferences on Chinese Social Media." *International Studies Quarterly* 68 (March): sqae033.

Recommended

- Marcus, George E., W. Russell Neuman, and Michael MacKuen. 2000. *Affective Intelligence and Political Judgment*. University of Chicago Press.
- Pagano, Sabrina J., and Yuen J. Huo. 2007. "The Role of Moral Emotions in Predicting Support for Political Actions in Post-War Iraq." *Political Psychology* 28 (2): 227–255.
- Bleiker, Roland, and Emma Hutchison. 2008. "Fear No More: Emotions and World Politics." *Review of International Studies* 34: 115–135.
- Sasley, Brent E. 2010. "Affective Attachments and Foreign Policy: Israel and the 1993 Oslo Accords." *European Journal of International Relations* 16 (4): 687–709.
- Hutchison, Emma, and Roland Bleiker. 2014. "Theorizing Emotions in World Politics." *International Theory* 6 (3): 491–514.
- McDermott, Rose. 2014. "The Body Doesn't Lie: A Somatic Approach to the Study of Emotions in World Politics." *International Theory* 6 (3): 557–562.
- Hall, Todd H. 2015. *Emotional Diplomacy: Official Emotion on the International Stage*. Cornell University Press, ch. 1.
- Markwica, Robin. 2018. *Emotional Choices: How the Logic of Affect Shapes Coercive Diplomacy*. Oxford University Press.

UNIT 3: From Persons to States

The level-of-analysis problem. How individual psychology becomes state behavior, and why states come to look like persons in return.

Week 7 (October 22) — Microfoundations: How Do Individuals Matter?

How do psychological accounts of individual behavior scale up to state action?

- Hermann, Margaret G., and Charles F. Hermann. 1989. "Who Makes Foreign Policy Decisions and How: An Empirical Inquiry." *International Studies Quarterly* 33 (4): 361–387.
- Jost, Tyler, Joshua D. Kertzer, Eric Min, and Robert Schub. 2024. "Advisers and Aggregation in Foreign Policy Decision-Making." *International Organization* 78 (1): 1–37.
- Gelpi, Christopher, Peter D. Feaver, and Jason Reifler. 2005. "Success Matters: Casualty Sensitivity and the War in Iraq." *International Security* 30 (3): 7–46.
- Kertzer, Joshua D., and Thomas Zeitzoff. 2017. "A Bottom-Up Theory of Public Opinion about Foreign Policy." *American Journal of Political Science* 61 (3): 543–558.

Recommended

- Foyle, Douglas C. 2004. "Leading the Public to War? The Influence of American Public Opinion on the Bush Administration's Decision to Go to War in Iraq." *International Journal of Public Opinion Research* 16 (3): 269–294.
- Walker, Stephen G., Akan Malici, and Mark Schafer. 2011. *Rethinking Foreign Policy Analysis: States, Leaders, and the Microfoundations of Behavioral International Relations*. Routledge.
- Mintz, Alex, and Carly Wayne. 2016. "The Polythink Syndrome and Elite Group Decision-Making." *Political Psychology* 37: 3–21.
- Stein, Janice Gross. 2017. "The Micro-Foundations of International Relations Theory: Psychology and Behavioral Economics." *International Organization* 71 (S1): S249–S263.
- Horowitz, Michael, et al. 2019. "What Makes Foreign Policy Teams Tick: Explaining Variation in Group Performance at Geopolitical Forecasting." *Journal of Politics* 81 (4): 1388–1404.
- Tomz, Michael, Jessica L. P. Weeks, and Keren Yarhi-Milo. 2020. "Public Opinion and Decisions About Military Force in Democracies." *International Organization* 74 (1): 119–143.

Week 8 (October 29) — People Like States: National and Transnational Identities

Why do individuals think and feel as though they were the state?

This session will be rescheduled; I will be away this week. We will settle the arrangement as a class well in advance and announce it on CourseWorks. The Check-in 2 deadline of October 29 is unaffected.

- Mercer, Jonathan. 2014. "Feeling Like a State: Social Emotion and Identity." *International Theory* 6 (3): 515–535.
- Herrmann, Richard K. 2017. "How Attachments to the Nation Shape Beliefs About the World: A Theory of Motivated Reasoning." *International Organization* 71 (S1): S61–S84.
- Mansfield, Edward D., and Diana C. Mutz. 2009. "Support for Free Trade: Self-Interest, Sociotropic Politics, and Out-Group Anxiety." *International Organization* 63 (3): 425–457.
- Copelovitch, Mark, and Jon C. W. Pevehouse. 2019. "International Organizations in a New Era of Populist Nationalism." *The Review of International Organizations* 14 (2): 169–186.

Recommended

- Tajfel, Henri, and John Turner. 1986. "The Social Identity Theory of Intergroup Behavior." In *Psychology of Intergroup Relations*, ed. S. Worchel and W. Austin. Chicago: Nelson-Hall.
- Brewer, Marilynn B. 2001. "The Many Faces of Social Identity: Implications for Political Psychology." *Political Psychology* 22 (1): 115–125.
- Kurzban, Robert, John Tooby, and Leda Cosmides. 2001. "Can Race Be Erased? Coalitional Computation and Social Categorization." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 98 (26): 15387–15392.
- Powlick, Philip J., and Andrew Z. Katz. 1998. "Defining the American Public Opinion/Foreign Policy Nexus." *Mershon International Studies Review* 42 (Supplement 1): 29–61.
- Wenzel, Michael, Amélie Mummendey, and Sven Waldzus. 2007. "Superordinate Identities and Intergroup Conflict: The Ingroup Projection Model." *European Review of Social Psychology* 18: 331–372.
- Baum, Matthew A., and Philip B. K. Potter. 2019. "Media, Public Opinion, and Foreign Policy in the Age of Social Media." *The Journal of Politics* 81 (2): 747–756.
- Ko, Jiyoung. 2022. "Not So Dangerous? Nationalism and Foreign Policy Preference." *International Studies Quarterly* 66 (3): sqac053.
- Zhou, Yang-Yang, and Jason Lyall. 2025. "Prolonged Contact Does Not Reshape Locals' Attitudes Toward Migrants in Wartime Settings." *American Journal of Political Science* 69: 210–222.
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Week 9 (November 5) — States Like People: Status, Reputation, and Recognition

Why do states behave as though they had the needs of persons: standing, status, and reputation?

- Gries, Peter Hays. 2005. "Social Psychology and the Identity-Conflict Debate: Is the 'China Threat' Inevitable?" *European Journal of International Relations* 11 (2): 235–265.
- Larson, Deborah Welch, and Alexei Shevchenko. 2010. "Status Seekers: Chinese and Russian Responses to U.S. Primacy." *International Security* 34 (4): 63–95.
- Renshon, Jonathan. 2016. "Status Deficits and War." *International Organization* 70 (3): 513–550.

- Jo, Eun A. 2022. "Memory, Institutions, and the Domestic Politics of South Korean–Japanese Relations." *International Organization* 76 (4): 767–798.

Recommended

- Huth, Paul K. 1997. "Reputations and Deterrence: A Theoretical and Empirical Assessment." *Security Studies* 7 (1): 72–99.
- Wendt, Alexander. 2003. "Why a World State Is Inevitable." *European Journal of International Relations* 9 (4): 491–542.
- Hymans, Jacques E. C. 2006. *The Psychology of Nuclear Proliferation: Identity, Emotions and Foreign Policy*. Cambridge University Press.
- Dafoe, Allan, Jonathan Renshon, and Paul Huth. 2014. "Reputation and Status as Motives for War." *Annual Review of Political Science* 17: 371–393.
- Pu, Xiaoyu. 2017. "Controversial Identity of a Rising China." *The Chinese Journal of International Politics* 10 (2): 131–149.
- Ward, Steven. 2017. "Lost in Translation: Social Identity Theory and the Study of Status in World Politics." *International Studies Quarterly* 61 (4): 821–834.
- Brutger, Ryan, and Joshua D. Kertzer. 2018. "A Dispositional Theory of Reputation Costs." *International Organization* 72 (3): 693–724.
- Quek, Kai, and Alastair Iain Johnston. 2018. "Can China Back Down? Crisis De-escalation in the Shadow of Popular Opposition." *International Security* 42 (3): 7–36.
- Jervis, Robert, Keren Yarhi-Milo, and Don Casler. 2021. "Redefining the Debate over Reputation and Credibility in International Security: Promises and Limits of New Scholarship." *World Politics* 73 (1): 167–203.
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UNIT 4: Psychology Applied

Three standing questions in world politics: what leaders bring with them, how beliefs harden into commitments, and what violence leaves behind.

Week 10 (November 12) — Personality, Predispositions, and Values

People differ, enduringly, in temperament and values. Which dispositions shape foreign-policy orientations?

- Walker, Stephen G., Mark Schafer, and Gary Smith. 2020. "The Operational Codes of Donald Trump and Hillary Clinton." In *Oxford Handbook of Behavioral Political Science*, ed. Alex Mintz and Lesley Terris. Oxford University Press.
- Kertzer, Joshua D., et al. 2014. "Moral Support: How Moral Values Shape Foreign Policy Attitudes." *Journal of Politics* 76 (3): 825–840.
- Rathbun, Brian C., et al. 2016. "Taking Foreign Policy Personally: Personal Values and Foreign Policy Attitudes." *International Studies Quarterly* 60 (1): 124–137.
- Chu, Jonathan A. 2021. "Liberal Ideology and Foreign Opinion on China." *International Studies Quarterly* 65 (4): 960–972.

Recommended

- Cohrs, J. Christopher, Barbara Moschner, and Jürgen Maes. 2005. "The Motivational Bases of Right-Wing Authoritarianism and Social Dominance Orientation." *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin* 31 (10): 1425–1434.
- Rathbun, Brian C. 2007. "Hierarchy and Community at Home and Abroad: Evidence of a Common Structure of Domestic and Foreign Policy Beliefs in American Elites." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 51 (3): 379–407.
- Caprara, Gian Vittorio, and Michele Vecchione. 2013. "Personality Approaches to Political Behavior." In *The Oxford Handbook of Political Psychology*, ed. Huddy, Sears, and Levy. Oxford University Press.
- Gries, Peter Hays. 2014. *The Politics of American Foreign Policy: How Ideology Divides Liberals and Conservatives over Foreign Affairs*. Stanford University Press.
- Jost, John T. 2017. "Ideological Asymmetries and the Essence of Political Psychology." *Political Psychology* 38 (2): 167–208.
- Bertoli, Andrew, Allan Dafoe, and Robert F. Trager. 2019. "Is There a War Party? Party Change, the Left–Right Divide, and International Conflict." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 63 (4): 950–975.

Week 11 (November 19) — The Unspeakable and the Non-Negotiable

Why do some beliefs harden into commitments that cannot be bargained, taboos and indivisible issues, and with what effect?

Final policy memo due Friday, November 20.

- Tannenwald, Nina. 1999. "The Nuclear Taboo: The United States and the Normative Basis of Nuclear Non-Use." *International Organization* 53 (3): 433–468.
- Goddard, Stacie E. 2006. "Uncommon Ground: Indivisible Territory and the Politics of Legitimacy." *International Organization* 60 (1): 35–68.
- McDermott, Rose, et al. 2009. "Monoamine Oxidase A Gene (MAOA) Predicts Behavioral Aggression Following Provocation." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 106 (7): 2118–2123.
- Wendt, Alexander, and Raymond Duvall. 2008. "Sovereignty and the UFO." *Political Theory* 36 (4): 607–633.

Recommended

- Price, Richard. 1995. "The Genealogy of the Chemical Weapons Taboo." *International Organization* 49 (1): 73–103.
- Fiske, Alan Page, and Philip E. Tetlock. 1997. "Taboo Trade-offs: Reactions to Transactions That Transgress the Spheres of Justice." *Political Psychology* 18 (2): 255–297.

- Press, Daryl G., Scott D. Sagan, and Benjamin A. Valentino. 2013. "Atomic Aversion: Experimental Evidence on Taboos, Traditions, and the Non-Use of Nuclear Weapons." *American Political Science Review* 107 (1): 188–206.
- Haslam, Nick, and Steve Loughnan. 2014. "Dehumanization and Infrahumanization." *Annual Review of Psychology* 65: 399–423.
- Avey, Paul C. 2021. "MAD and Taboo: US Expert Views on Nuclear Deterrence, Coercion, and Non-Use Norms." *Foreign Policy Analysis* 17 (January): oraa019.
- Kennard, Amanda. 2021. "My Brother's Keeper: Other-Regarding Preferences and Concern for Global Climate Change." *The Review of International Organizations* 16: 345–376.
- Yoon, Hohyun. 2024. "Anger Expressions and Coercive Credibility in International Crises." *American Journal of Political Science* (forthcoming).

Week 12 (December 3) — Post-Conflict Transition

What legacies of violence remain in our minds?

Written feedback on the memo returned Tuesday, December 1.

- Kim, Jiyeon. Forthcoming. "When Empathy Goes Viral: The Emotional Loop in Human Rights Advocacy." *International Studies Quarterly*.
- Branscombe, Nyla R., Bertjan Doosje, and Craig McGarty. 2016. "Antecedents and Consequences of Collective Guilt." In *From Prejudice to Intergroup Emotions*, 49–66. Psychology Press.
- Myrick, Rachel. 2021. "Do External Threats Unite or Divide? Security Crises, Rivalries, and Polarization in American Foreign Policy." *International Organization* 75 (4): 921–958.
- Imhoff, Roland, et al. 2017. "Explaining the Inexplicable: Differences in Attributions for the Holocaust in Germany, Israel, and Poland." *Political Psychology* 38 (6): 907–924.

Recommended

- Lind, Jennifer. 2008. *Sorry States: Apologies in International Politics*. Cornell University Press, ch. 1.
- Noor, Masi, Nurit Shnabel, Samer Halabi, and Arie Nadler. 2012. "When Suffering Begets Suffering: The Psychology of Competitive Victimhood Between Adversarial Groups in Violent Conflicts." *Personality and Social Psychology Review* 16 (4): 351–374.
- Getmansky, Anna, and Thomas Zeitzoff. 2014. "Terrorism and Voting: The Effect of Rocket Threat on Voting in Israeli Elections." *American Political Science Review* 108 (3): 588–604.
- Stein, Rachel. 2015. "War and Revenge: Explaining Conflict Initiation by Democracies." *American Political Science Review* 109 (3): 556–573.
- Lupu, Noam, and Leonid Peisakhin. 2017. "The Legacy of Political Violence across Generations." *American Journal of Political Science* 61 (4): 836–851.
- Wayne, Carly, and Yuri M. Zhukov. 2022. "Never Again: The Holocaust and Political Legacies of Genocide." *World Politics* 74 (3): 367–404.

- Kim, James D. 2024. "The Long-Run Impact of Childhood Wartime Violence on Preferences for Nuclear Proliferation." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 68 (1): 108–137.

Week 13 (December 10) — Policy Briefings

Each group delivers its ten-minute policy briefing, followed by questions from the class. Last class meeting. No new readings.

Examination period

No class meetings, no exam, and nothing due. All coursework is complete by the last class meeting on December 10. Nothing in this course is due during the reading period of December 15–16.

Policy on the Use of Generative AI

This course treats generative AI the way the policy world does: as a tool you should know how to use, and one you may not outsource your judgment to.

Permitted. You may use generative AI tools to check and correct language mistakes; to generate ideas and facilitate brainstorming; to locate sources; and to clarify concepts from the readings. SIPA explicitly encourages the use of AI for language correction, and so do I: if English is not your first language, these tools can help your writing show your thinking.

Prohibited. Submitting AI-generated prose or analysis as your own work is plagiarism under the Code of Academic & Professional Conduct. The argument, the analysis, and the final wording of everything you submit must be yours.

Required disclosure. If you use AI on work you submit, add a short note at the end of it telling me three things: which tool you used, what you used it for, and what you changed afterward. Two or three sentences is usually enough. If AI shaped the substance of the work rather than just the wording, include the exchange itself, or the parts of it that mattered.

Disclosing costs you nothing. Using AI to correct your English, clarify a reading, or get unstuck is permitted, and saying so will not affect your grade. Not disclosing it is the violation.

No detection software. I will not run your work through AI-detection tools: they are unreliable and biased against non-native English speakers. This policy relies on disclosure, and on your ability to stand behind your work.

Standing behind your work. You should expect to explain and defend any part of what you submit, in class or in conversation with me; inability to do so will be treated as evidence that the work is not your own. The course is built so that this is routine rather than punitive. You present your own reflection memo to the seminar and field questions on it, you respond in writing to your classmates' memos on a deadline that leaves no room for a ghostwriter, and you take questions on the group briefing. Work that is genuinely yours will be easy to stand behind in all three settings.

Academic Integrity Statement

The School of International and Public Affairs does not tolerate cheating or plagiarism in any form. Students who violate the Code of Academic & Professional Conduct will be referred to the Office of Student Affairs, under the Dean of Students, and may be subject to disciplinary procedures. Violations may include plagiarism, unauthorized collaboration, and the use of generative AI or other tools in ways that are inconsistent with course policies.

Disability Accommodations Statement

SIPA is committed to supporting all students in fully participating in their academic programs. Students registered with Columbia University's Disability Services (DS) are entitled to reasonable accommodations.

If you have a DS-certified accommodation letter, you are encouraged to connect with your instructor to discuss how these accommodations will be implemented in the course. Faculty will work with you to ensure that approved accommodations are in place.

If you have questions or would like additional support, please contact SIPA Student Affairs' Wellness Dean and liaison with Columbia University's Disability Services at disability@sipa.columbia.edu or 212-854-8690.

Additional Course Policies

- **Late work:** written submissions lose one-third of a letter grade per 24 hours late. If something is going wrong in your life, come talk to me *before* the deadline; I can work with almost anything except silence. University rules also mean I cannot accept work after the semester ends unless you have an approved Incomplete.
- **Communication:** I'll answer email within 24 hours on weekdays and 48 hours on weekends, so please write well in advance of deadlines. Emergencies get priority.
- **Grade disputes:** per SIPA policy, only final course grades may be appealed; individual assignment grades are not subject to appeal. If you believe your final grade was miscalculated, contact me first for clarification and a breakdown of the calculation. After that good-faith step, a formal appeal may be submitted to SIPA Academic Affairs no later than fifteen business days after the end of the term (or before degree conferral, whichever comes first).
- **Revisions:** any opportunity to revise or redo submitted work will be offered to the entire class and announced in advance, through the syllabus or CourseWorks; I cannot grant individual redos or post-semester make-up work.
- **Civility:** constructive disagreement is the point of a seminar; address the argument, not the person.